

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Higher Education and Research English



Teacher's guide

Teach practical workplace communication with specific cases, clear language targets, and a repeatable feedback process.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Study complete conversations. Find the right language, speak, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For faculty, postdoctoral researchers, graduate students, lab managers, research administrators, grant staff, ethics-board coordinators, and academic program leaders.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Your course at a glance

Use the lesson numbers to match this document with the website and the other guides.

01 Research Questions and Study Design

Clarify missing information before responding.

02 Grant Proposals and Specific Aims

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

03 Lab Meetings and Data Challenges

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

04 Research Ethics and Human Subjects

Clarify missing information before responding.

05 Authorship, Collaboration, and Credit

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

06 Peer Review and Revision Responses

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

07 Data Management and Reproducibility

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

08 Academic Presentations and Conferences

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

Choose your pace

Quick practice: spend 15 minutes reading one conversation and rehearsing one scenario. Full lesson: allow 45-60 minutes for language work, three conversations, two speaking scenarios, and feedback.

Level support

B1 learners can use the frames and a partner. B2 learners can try a response before reading the model. C1 learners can add the harder follow-up and reduce preparation time. These are teaching suggestions, not certified CEFR level ratings.

After practicing: open the AI prompt workshop, or use the prompts at the end of this guide.

A 60-minute lesson that works

Prepare the case and the learner pages. Keep the model response hidden until learners have attempted their own. Choose two field terms that are important to understanding the case.

0-5 minutes | Activate experience

Ask learners to name a comparable situation without sharing confidential details. Introduce the communication goal.

5-12 minutes | Read and sort facts

Read the case. Learners identify confirmed facts, unknowns, the audience, and the immediate communication need.

12-22 minutes | Notice and practice language

Explain the workshop pattern. Work through the vocabulary and editing example, then discuss both language checks and the reasons behind the choices.

22-35 minutes | 05 • Conversations

Read one ten-turn conversation aloud, notice a useful expression, then compare the other two. Identify each speaker's purpose and how the exchange ends.

35-47 minutes | 06 • Say it

Rehearse both speaking scenarios from the workbook. Give two minutes of preparation, switch roles, and use the success checks. Add the complication only after a successful first round.

47-55 minutes | Compare and revise

Reveal the model. Discuss alternative acceptable wording. Give one meaning correction and one language correction, then repeat.

55-60 minutes | Retrieve and transfer

Close the materials. Learners recall two expressions and identify one communication habit to use in another situation.

Adapt the session

For 45 minutes, study one complete conversation and rehearse one scenario; assign the others for oral follow-up. For 90 minutes, rehearse all three conversations and give both scenarios a second round. More time should produce more meaningful practice, not longer explanations.

LESSON 01 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Research Questions and Study Design

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A research proposal asks whether a program "works" without specifying the outcome or population.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: research question, hypothesis, methodology, limitation.

Model response

What outcome would count as improvement, for whom, and over what period? A clearer research question will help us choose an appropriate design and describe its limits.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. A - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. C - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. What does works mean in this proposal? - Fictional study-design meeting using the lesson case: a proposal asks whether a program works but does not identify an outcome or population.
2. Compare experiences or estimate an effect? - Fictional research planning: a team proposes interviews about a mentoring program, while a sponsor expects a numerical estimate of its causal effect.
3. The population is broader than the available sample - Fictional proposal discussion: a researcher can recruit from one evening seminar but has written a question about all university students.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A six-month outcome with a two-week study

A fictional proposal asks about six-month persistence, but its planned observation lasts two weeks. No later data access is confirmed. Clarify whether to change the research question or assess a longer design.

Role A: Research supervisor: explain the mismatch between outcome and observation period.

Role B: Researcher: propose a bounded short-term question without claiming long-term persistence.

Possible opening: Our two-week observation cannot directly establish the six-month outcome named in the question.

Success checks

- Distinguish short-term observation from long-term outcome.
- Do not assume later data access.
- Agree a question or design revision for review.

Add a complication: The researcher suggests labeling two-week attendance as six-month persistence.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 02 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Grant Proposals and Specific Aims

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

A grant draft promises to solve a broad scientific problem using a small pilot study.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: specific aims, significance, innovation, feasibility.

Model response

The pilot can test feasibility and provide preliminary evidence. It cannot resolve the entire problem. I'll narrow the aim so the proposed work and the claim match.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. C - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.
2. B - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 • Conversations

1. A pilot can test feasibility, not solve the whole field - Fictional grant review using the lesson case: a small pilot promises to solve a broad scientific problem.
2. A promised recruitment rate has no pilot evidence - Fictional grant planning: a team proposes recruiting 30 participants in a month but has no recruitment-rate data or confirmed access arrangement.
3. Innovation does not guarantee superior performance - Fictional proposal review: a researcher calls a new measurement approach more accurate, although no comparison with the existing method has been completed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The available equipment has not been reserved

A fictional grant budget assumes access to a shared instrument for four weeks. The facility has expressed interest but has not confirmed availability. Discuss feasibility wording and the information needed before claiming secured access.

Role A: Research administrator: identify the difference between interest and confirmed access.

Role B: Principal investigator: propose a conditional access request and honest grant wording.

Possible opening: The facility has expressed interest, but the four-week instrument allocation is not yet confirmed.

Success checks

- Keep proposed and confirmed resources separate.
- State the effect on feasibility without predicting rejection.
- Agree a specific facility confirmation request.

Add a complication: A collaborator asks to call the equipment reserved because the proposal deadline is close.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 03 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Lab Meetings and Data Challenges

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A result differs from an earlier experiment, but the lab notes omit a protocol change.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: control, replication, protocol drift, analysis assumption.

Model response

Could we compare the protocol versions and recorded conditions? Please add the missing change to the record so the team can assess possible explanations for the difference.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. B - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. A - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 · Conversations

1. The replication notes omit a protocol change - Fictional lab meeting using the lesson case: a new result differs from an earlier experiment, but the notes omit a protocol change.
2. A control label is not a complete control definition - Fictional lab review: two datasets use the label control, but their treatment and collection conditions are not described together.

3. An undocumented exclusion rule leaves comparability unresolved - Fictional analysis review: one run excluded incomplete records, while an earlier summary does not document its exclusion rule.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The instrument setting is absent from the notes

A fictional replication uses an instrument whose setting was recorded for the new run but omitted from the earlier notes. The older setting is unknown. Request source information without assuming the two runs used the same value.

Role A: Lab coordinator: ask for the earlier instrument record and relevant protocol reference.

Role B: Research associate: identify available records and preserve unrecoverable gaps.

Possible opening: We have the new setting, but could you locate evidence for the setting used in the earlier run?

Success checks

- Do not backfill an unknown historical setting.
- Request a specific source record.
- Keep replication comparability unresolved until reviewed.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests copying the new value into the old notes to make them complete.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 04 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Research Ethics and Human Subjects

Clarify missing information before responding.

CASE

A researcher wants to reuse participant data for a new question. The existing approval and consent materials have not been reviewed.

Teach this move

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Vocabulary to check: IRB, informed consent, secondary use, human subjects.

Model response

Does the proposed use fall within the relevant approval and consent arrangements? Let's check with the appropriate ethics and data-governance processes before assuming reuse is permitted.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. After an introductory phrase such as 'Could you explain', the embedded question uses statement word order: "what this means".

Second-round challenge

The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Language-check answers

1. A - Could you confirm when the review starts? The embedded question uses subject then verb: "the review starts".
2. C - Has the report been approved, or is it ready for review? This question distinguishes two meanings of 'ready' that affect the next action.

05 • Conversations

1. A new question needs an approval-scope check - Fictional research-ethics discussion using the lesson case: a researcher wants secondary use of participant data before reviewing existing approval and consent materials.
2. Public availability does not answer every ethics question - Fictional research planning: a team proposes studying publicly accessible forum posts; institutional review applicability and data handling have not been assessed.

3. Translated consent materials have unconfirmed review status - Fictional study preparation: translated participant information exists, but its review and approval status are unconfirmed; recruitment has not begun.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A collaborator asks for identifiable records

A fictional collaborator requests identifiable participant records for a new analysis. The original consent and collaboration-access arrangements have not been checked. No transfer has occurred. Clarify scope and the appropriate review route.

Role A: Principal investigator: describe the proposed use and identify the missing approval checks.

Role B: Ethics coordinator: ask about fields, purpose, access, and existing documents.

Possible opening: Before any transfer, we need to check whether the proposed access and purpose are covered by the relevant approvals and consent.

Success checks

- Do not equate seniority with approved access.
- Identify specific documents and proposed-use details.
- Keep transfer pending the responsible review.

Add a complication: The collaborator's seniority is offered as sufficient authorization.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 05 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Authorship, Collaboration, and Credit

Include relevant voices and clarify the decision process.

CASE

Collaborators disagree about authorship late in a project. Their contributions and expectations have not been discussed together.

Teach this move

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Vocabulary to check: authorship, contribution, corresponding author, acknowledgment.

Model response

Could we document each contribution and review the applicable authorship criteria as a group? That will give us a clearer basis for the discussion than relying on assumptions about rank or effort.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revised question gives people a way to raise a concern. Silence can have several meanings, especially in unfamiliar or unequal-power situations.

Second-round challenge

A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Language-check answers

1. C - We haven't heard from the remote team yet; what is your view? It invites participation without interpreting silence as consent.
2. B - Approval is pending; the sponsor will review the two options. This distinguishes discussion from approval and identifies the next reviewer.

05 • Conversations

1. Discuss contributions before deciding authorship - Separate fictional credit discussion: a collaborating researcher designed an interview guide and analyzed 20 transcripts, but has not drafted manuscript text. The researcher expected authorship; a draft lists an acknowledgment. Applicable criteria have not been reviewed.

2. A software contributor was left out of the discussion - Separate fictional collaboration: a research software engineer built the analysis pipeline and tested missing-value handling but was absent from the credit discussion. The engineer expects authorship consideration and an accurate software contribution description. Eligibility is unassessed.

3. An old author order is not current agreement - Separate fictional manuscript discussion: an early draft lists a collaborating statistician third. Since that draft, the statistician completed a sensitivity analysis and revised the results interpretation. The statistician requests an order review, not a guaranteed position. Current agreement and applicable ordering guidance are unconfirmed.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | An acknowledgment was added without consultation

A fictional draft thanks a collaborator by name, but the team has not discussed the description with that person or reviewed the applicable publication expectations. Discuss a consultation route before finalizing the acknowledgment.

Role A: Manuscript coordinator: identify the unconfirmed wording and invite the collaborator's perspective.

Role B: Corresponding author: clarify the review process without deciding consent or credit on their behalf.

Possible opening: The acknowledgment names the collaborator, but we haven't confirmed the wording with them or checked the relevant requirements.

Success checks

- Avoid assuming agreement from a positive label.
- Distinguish proposed wording from confirmed participation.
- Agree who will consult the collaborator and review requirements.

Add a complication: A colleague says being thanked is always harmless and needs no discussion.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 06 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Peer Review and Revision Responses

Acknowledge a communication problem and give a corrected message.

CASE

A reviewer points out that a manuscript's claim goes beyond its sample. The authors agree that the wording needs revision.

Teach this move

Name what was unclear or wrong, acknowledge its effect, and correct it. A brief apology can help, followed by a practical next step. Avoid explaining away the other person's reaction or promising an outcome you cannot control.

Vocabulary to check: peer review, major revision, response letter, scope.

Model response

Thank you for identifying this limitation. We have narrowed the claim to the studied sample and added a discussion of generalizability. The response should point the reviewer to the revised passage.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision takes responsibility for the message without blaming the listener. It identifies what needs to be corrected.

Second-round challenge

The listener remains disappointed after the correction. Acknowledge the impact and restate the available next step calmly.

Language-check answers

1. B - I'm sorry my earlier wording was unclear. This acknowledges the speaker's contribution to the problem.
2. A - The corrected date and the current confirmation status. A repair needs usable corrected information, including any uncertainty.

05 • Conversations

1. A claim extends beyond the study sample - Fictional peer-review discussion using the lesson case: a reviewer identifies an overgeneralized claim, and the authors agree the wording needs revision.
2. The response says added, but the analysis is only proposed - Fictional revision meeting: a draft response says an additional analysis was added, although the team has only proposed it and has not run it.

3. Clarify an ambiguous comparison in the manuscript - Fictional peer review: a reviewer read better outcomes as a between-group comparison, but the analysis only describes change within one group.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | A table heading suggests a causal effect

A fictional manuscript table is headed Program effect, but it reports an unadjusted association from observational data. The authors agree the heading is too strong. Discuss an accurate replacement and how to explain the correction to the reviewer.

Role A: Lead author: acknowledge the overstatement and propose association-based wording.

Role B: Coauthor: check that the response describes a wording correction, not new causal evidence.

Possible opening: The heading overstates the analysis; it should describe an observed association rather than a program effect.

Success checks

- Acknowledge the specific wording problem.
- Preserve the observational scope.
- Agree to verify the manuscript and response match before submission.

Add a complication: A collaborator wants to keep the stronger heading because it attracts attention.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 07 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Data Management and Reproducibility

Make a request with a clear action, purpose, and realistic timing.

CASE

A shared dataset has variable names but no description of units, missing values, or collection dates.

Teach this move

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Vocabulary to check: metadata, repository, provenance, reproducibility.

Model response

Could you add a data dictionary covering units, missing-value codes, and collection dates? Those details will help another researcher interpret and reuse the data correctly.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision names the document and requested response. It avoids expressions that may be unfamiliar or ambiguous for an international audience.

Second-round challenge

The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

Language-check answers

1. A - Send it no later than Thursday. 'By' sets the latest point, while 'after' refers to a later time.
2. C - Could you confirm the document version needed for the review? The requested action and information are explicit.

05 • Conversations

1. Variable names need units and missing-value definitions - Fictional data handoff using the lesson case: a shared dataset has variable names but no units, missing-value descriptions, or collection dates.
2. Zero may mean a measurement or a missing code - Fictional dataset review: a variable contains zeros, but the data dictionary does not explain whether zero is a legitimate observation or missing-value code.

3. A repository file changed after analysis - Fictional reproducibility review: a shared data file was replaced after analysis; the analyst recorded a version identifier, but the current filename is unchanged.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | Collection dates use two ambiguous formats

A fictional dataset includes dates such as 03/04/2025 from two source teams. Their date conventions are undocumented, and the source forms have not been checked. Request clarification before chronological analysis.

Role A: Research analyst: explain the ambiguity and preserve original values.

Role B: Data curator: identify source-team records needed to confirm interpretation.

Possible opening: This date could mean March fourth or April third; we need each source team's convention before ordering observations.

Success checks

- Do not infer dates from a preferred result.
- Request source-specific documentation.
- Preserve raw values and record the eventual verified transformation.

Add a complication: A colleague suggests choosing the interpretation that makes the trend smoother.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

LESSON 08 / FACILITATOR NOTES

Academic Presentations and Conferences

Separate observations, assumptions, and conclusions.

CASE

An audience member asks whether a small study proves a general theory. The presenter needs a concise answer.

Teach this move

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Vocabulary to check: generalizability, limitation, future work, conference Q&A.

Model response

The study offers evidence relevant to the theory under these conditions. It does not establish the theory in every setting. A useful next step would test whether the finding holds in a broader sample.

Listen for, then coach

Ask learners to point to the case fact behind each important statement. Accept different wording when it preserves meaning, fits the listener, and does not invent an outcome. The revision states the finding and its scope. It avoids turning limited evidence into a universal claim.

Second-round challenge

Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

Language-check answers

1. C - The change may have contributed to the delay. 'May have contributed' presents a possibility without claiming the cause is established.

2. B - In this pilot, the observed result was ... This locates the finding in the setting actually studied.

05 · Conversations

1. A small study does not prove a general theory - Fictional conference Q&A using the lesson case: an audience researcher asks whether a small study proves a general theory.

2. A question asks for a result that was not measured - Fictional conference exchange: a presenter reports task completion, and an audience researcher asks whether participants also became more confident; confidence was

not measured.

3. An unfamiliar setting is outside the sample - Fictional conference Q&A: a study was conducted in one campus writing center, and a researcher asks whether the result applies to workplace training.

Use the complete ten-turn scripts in the learner workbook and conversation lab. Read with roles, identify the decision or open question, then replay without reading.

06 · Say it: second scenario | The audience asks whether no difference proves equivalence

A fictional small study found no clear difference between two conditions. It was not designed as an equivalence study. An audience member asks whether the conditions are therefore interchangeable. Give a concise, bounded answer.

Role A: Research presenter: distinguish no clear detected difference from established equivalence.

Role B: Audience researcher: ask what further design or evidence would address equivalence.

Possible opening: We did not establish equivalence; this study found no clear difference under its particular design and conditions.

Success checks

- Do not convert an inconclusive comparison into equivalence.
- State the design boundary in plain language.
- Identify equivalence as a separate future research question.

Add a complication: The questioner asks for a simple yes that removes the limitation.

AI extension: adapt this lesson for your learners and available time.

Give feedback that helps

Score each criterion 0, 1, or 2. This is a practice rubric, not a professional qualification or CEFR test. Do not award or remove points for a particular accent.

Meaning and accuracy

Keeps the case facts accurate; clearly separates confirmed and unknown information.

Clarity and language

Uses understandable sentences and explains specialist terms when the listener needs it.

Interaction and tone

Responds to the other person's question, checks understanding, and uses an appropriate tone.

Task completion

Makes the requested action or unresolved question clear without inventing authority or facts.

Use the same scale for each criterion

0 - Not yet: The reader or listener cannot yet recover the intended meaning or action.

1 - With support: The message works after a prompt, clarification, or revision.

2 - Independently: The message is clear and accurate without a prompt.

Feedback sequence

First, identify a successful phrase. Next, identify one point where meaning or accuracy needs work. Offer one useful language correction, allow a repeat, and compare the two attempts. A total out of eight describes this performance only; do not translate it into a proficiency level.

Final challenge

Choose a case not rehearsed today. The learner gives a one-minute response, answers two follow-up questions, and writes a 70-110 word message. Add the lesson's second-round challenge. Compare the result with an earlier attempt using the four criteria.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

US Department of Education: FERPA

<https://studentprivacy.ed.gov/ferpa>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.

Extend your practice with AI

Use the next two prompts after your own first attempt. Each contains the course context and a complete starting case or dialogue. Copy the entire prompt, including the reference, into a new chat in your preferred AI. You can also use the links to copy it from the website.

Choose the right kind of help

A role-play prompt makes the AI wait for your replies. A new-dialogue prompt asks for a complete professional script. Writing feedback begins with your draft. Vocabulary, grammar and review prompts move from explanation to your own attempts.

Choose any lesson or dialogue online

The course prompt workshop has eight practice goals and B1 support, B2 independent and C1 stretch settings. These are practice choices, not assessed proficiency levels. Select the same lesson number or dialogue title you used in this guide.

[Open this course's AI prompt workshop](#)

Keep practice useful

Use fictional or anonymized details. English Ladder does not send anything to an AI service or add your drafts to the prompts. Your chosen service's terms and any usage charges apply. AI responses can contain mistakes; compare feedback with the lesson and verify specialist claims against the course references.

The two starter prompts use B2 practice. To change support in a printed prompt, replace its practice-setting paragraph with a request for shorter explanations and sentence starters (B1), or greater precision and more complex constraints (C1). Keep the professional facts unchanged.

Changing the example

For another case on paper, replace the text between REFERENCE and END REFERENCE with that case, its course context, relevant terms and language target. Include the full exchange if practicing a dialogue. Do not assume your AI can access this PDF or a link. The website makes this substitution for you.

Prompt edition: 2026-09-06. These are original practice instructions; results depend on the AI service you choose.

Adapt a partner or class activity

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Higher Education and Research English

Professional audience: faculty, postdoctoral researchers, graduate students, lab managers, research administrators, grant staff, ethics-board coordinators, and academic program leaders

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Research Questions and Study Design

Original fictional case: A research proposal asks whether a program "works" without specifying the outcome or population.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: research question: The specific question a study is designed to investigate. / hypothesis: A proposed explanation or prediction that can be examined using evidence. / methodology: The methods and reasoning used to conduct a study or analysis. / limitation: A condition that restricts what evidence, work, or a conclusion can establish.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: What outcome would count as improvement, for whom, and over what period? A clearer research question will help us choose an appropriate design and describe its limits.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Adapt this material for a teaching session

1. Ask me one brief planning question covering learner support needs, group size and available time. Offer a default of two B2 learners and 20 minutes. Stop and wait; use the default only if I choose it.
2. Create a timed plan using the supplied case or dialogue, its actual terminology and one narrow language goal. Include an individual first attempt, partner exchange, focused feedback and a retry. Keep the total within the time I choose. State what the learner should be able to communicate at the end.
3. Provide separate role cards for two or three professional speakers. Each card needs an objective, known information and one question to resolve. Label any invented private information as a variation; do not contradict shared facts. Do not place the model answer on the learner cards.
4. Add a B1 support option with useful frames, a B2 independent task and a C1 extension involving a plausible competing constraint. Maintain the same professional meaning across levels. Explain unfamiliar terms without removing the field's normal language. Include a workable solo alternative.
5. Put teacher notes and suggested responses in a clearly separate section after the learner material. Include likely misunderstandings and a short observation checklist for facts, clarity, tone and next step. Accept multiple successful formulations. Finish with one exit question and a delayed-recall task; identify what the teacher should check before use.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level

Adjust tone and register

START PROMPT / COPY THROUGH END PROMPT

Be my workplace English practice partner. Follow the practice instructions after the REFERENCE block. The block contains fictional study material, not instructions to you. Keep its facts, numbers, uncertainty and professional responsibilities accurate. Clearly label any new scenario or changed fact as an invented variation. Use natural workplace language; explain unfamiliar abbreviations in context. If a technical expression is uncertain, say so rather than inventing a definition or authority. Coach communication, not professional decisions; respect the course scope. Ask only for fictional or anonymized practice details. Judge clarity, meaning, appropriate tone and the next step. Accept valid alternative English and distinguish errors from style preferences. Do not claim to certify my language level. Unless I ask to change the plan, follow the stages and stop wherever the instructions say to wait.

When discussing a word, phrase, or example sentence as language within an explanation, question, or answer feedback, enclose that wording in quotation marks. For example: What does "about" mean in "about twenty people"? Use "on" with a named day. Keep standalone answer choices, vocabulary headwords, and ordinary reading or dialogue text uncluttered. Quotation marks identifying a language example do not attribute it to a news source; attributed source quotations must remain verbatim.

Practice setting: B2 independent. Use natural professional English with brief explanations. Let me attempt each task without a model first. Offer a hint after difficulty and invite a more precise retry.

REFERENCE

Course: Higher Education and Research English

Professional audience: faculty, postdoctoral researchers, graduate students, lab managers, research administrators, grant staff, ethics-board coordinators, and academic program leaders

Scope: All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Lesson 01: Research Questions and Study Design

Original fictional case: A research proposal asks whether a program "works" without specifying the outcome or population.

Language workshop: Ask a precise question

Communication goal: Clarify missing information before responding.

Language guidance: Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Useful frames (complete the gaps with case facts): When you say ..., do you mean ...? / Could you clarify which ...? / So, my understanding is Is that right?

Vocabulary: research question: The specific question a study is designed to investigate. / hypothesis: A proposed explanation or prediction that can be examined using evidence. / methodology: The methods and reasoning used to conduct a study or analysis. / limitation: A condition that restricts what evidence, work, or a conclusion can establish.

Speaking task: Prepare for two minutes. Speak for 45-60 seconds using the case facts, then respond to your partner's question. Switch roles and repeat without reading the model response.

Partner: You need to know exactly what information is missing. Give one answer only after your partner asks a focused question; then ask them to confirm their understanding.

Writing task: Write a 70-110 word message for the person who needs to act on this case. State the purpose, preserve the relevant facts, and make the next action or unresolved question clear. Use a subject line and an appropriate opening. Do not invent a deadline, finding, or approval.

Optional second-round challenge: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

Model for comparison AFTER my attempt, not a response to give me first: What outcome would count as improvement, for whom, and over what period? A clearer research question will help us choose an appropriate design and describe its limits.

END REFERENCE

TASK: Match the language to the listener

1. Choose a short message or utterance from the reference and quote it exactly. Identify its purpose and likely audience. Ask me to choose a new audience: a close colleague, a decision-maker, or an external reader who may not know the jargon. Stop and wait.
2. Ask me to adapt that message for the chosen reader, keeping its facts and degree of certainty unchanged. Offer a short frame only if I request help. Wait for my attempt before showing alternatives.
3. Discuss at most three choices in my version: directness, specialist vocabulary and interpersonal tone. Explain when a direct request is clearer than extra politeness, and when an unfamiliar abbreviation needs expansion. Avoid cultural stereotypes or claims that one nationality always communicates a certain way.
4. Show two natural alternatives, such as a concise spoken version and a more explicit written version. Explain the tradeoff in each. Do not turn a request into an order, a possibility into a promise, or a pending decision into approval.
5. Ask me to respond to one realistic follow-up from the new reader, then wait. Finish by asking me to adapt the message for a second audience without losing its core meaning. Give feedback only after the attempt.

END PROMPT

Copy this prompt online or choose another lesson and support level